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Buster Williams

Bassist Buster Williams was born on April 17, 1942 in Camden, New Jersey. He possesses one of the most distinctive sounds in all of jazz and has appeared as a sideman on a lengthy list of notable recordings. He currently tours and records with his own group, "Something More."

Buster was interviewed in New York City on January 6, 2002 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Manhattan and I've very pleased to have bassist Buster Williams with me for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. Thank you for coming today. It looks like your group "Something More" has a couple of busy months coming up.

BW: Oh yeah, you've been to the web site.

MR: Yes I have.

BW: Yeah. You know I've been trying to be really busy with that band since 1990. I did an album for a label, In and Out Records, a label out of Germany. I did it in 1987. And it was released in Europe and Asia until 1995 when it was released here. But I did that album and I wrote out a majority of the music for it, Herbie Hancock was on it, Wayne Shorter, Al Foster, trumpet player named Shunzo Ohno. And after doing the album, six months later I still liked it. You know? I mean you know how when you're working on something, you live with it so long and when it's done it's done, it's like a release and a relief, and if you never hear it again that's fine. But I liked it and I said well maybe it's time now for me to put my own band together, contrary to the way things are these days. You get a brand new shiny horn and the first thing you think about is making a CD and putting a band together. I mean because the powers that be tell you that's what you're supposed to do. Now when I came up it was all about apprenticeship, which is a valuable commodity that's being lost these days. But anyway that was the inspiration for me to put the band together, the fact that I still liked the music and maybe I would enjoy a night's performance of playing my own music. I sure did have my own, what I consider to be my concept of what an integral working unit should sound like. Also, as Duke Ellington said, one of the greatest reasons to have a band is so that you can hear your stuff.

MR: He certainly had that.

BW: Yeah. You get an idea, you write down some stuff and you've got somebody to play it for you.

MR: Yeah because it's a drag to have it all sitting around and you have no idea what it sounds like.

BW: Yeah, right. Anyway that was my inspiration for the band, and yes we do have a few busy months coming up, but it's still not as busy as I want it to be. I want to be able to work the majority of the year with my band.

MR: Is it a problem when you get, you do so much work, do you think you have to stop taking some of the calls in order to make room for your own band?

BW: Well it's a Catch 22 situation. Now it's one thing to set aside some time and you've got agents or whatever working for you guaranteeing that you'll be able to work this amount of time with your band. That's fine. And then of course as soon as you decide to do that all kinds of calls start coming in. When it rains it pours. And so you want to hope that the things that you're turning down you won't regret. And so that's one issue. The other is I do enjoy doing other things. And it keeps my perspective fresh and it keeps me well rounded. Now not to say that spending the majority of the time working with my own project wouldn't also give me that diversity, because I mean there are so many things that I want to do with my own project, there's many ideas that I'd like to have — I mean that I'd like to fulfill — that I can't fulfill if we've got three weeks and the band gets to popping and then you've got nothing for another three months. So it's a weird situation but I'm willing to take the chance that if my band can work 360 out of 365 days a year, great. Then I think I can stay interested and then as far as turning down other things, I like to try and make room to do other things. I don't want to have to take what I don't want to do. At this point, I mean I've been around a long time. You know you want to think that you can pick and choose. The world gets in the way many times.

MR: Well you said you had an apprenticeship of about 30 years before you put your band together. As you said, it's quite different these days with — it seems like the young musicians get pushed into that role.

BW: They get pushed away from where they need to be in order to establish something that's long-going. In this business the winner is the one who finishes last.

MR: Explain, if you don't mind.

BW: Well let's look at it. Look at Milt Hinton. Milt Hinton and I were on a movie date we were doing for Spike Lee, called "Clockers." Now I've known Milt for a long time. And Milt was, this was about six or seven years ago. So he was already up in years. And he had just done his first record as a leader. All these years, I mean playing with everybody, you know, Milton Berle, Bing Crosby, you know, and we were talking one day during the break and we were talking about all the attention that he was getting now. He says, "Where was everybody when I needed them? I could have used this thirty years ago." But that's what I'm talking about. Finishing. I mean you stay around long enough and it's all going to come to you just by virtue of the fact that you're still here. "What, you're still here?"

MR: You survived.

BW: You know, you deserve — so I mean hopefully things change to the point where it doesn't get to that. I feel that people need to be honored while they're alive. If they're worth anything while they're dead they must be worth something while they're alive. So that's what I mean by the winner is the one who finishes last. The one who stays around. I mean even in this society, a society such as the Asian society and Japan, they know how to treat elderly people. When people become old, they don't throw them aside. There's a wisdom that they have now. There's an intelligence that they have now. There's a wealth of experience that they have now that others can benefit from. You know the story of the bull? The big bull and the little bull? Up on top of the hill? And they're looking down into the valley and all of these cows are down there grazing you know? And the little bull is all excited, and he's feeling his oats, and he looks at the big bull and he says, "Why don't we run down there and make love to one of those cows?" And the big bull looks at the little bull chewing his cud and he says, "Why don't we walk down there and make love to all of them?" You know? You only get that wisdom from experience. You've got to live a little bit.

MR: Okay. That was a good one. Do you think — jazz has in the last, I don't know, about twenty years really is an art form has been elevated in this country. You've got all these universities now and you've got Jazz at Lincoln Center and all the things, but what has happened to it as far as employment opportunities and day to day life of a jazz musician?

BW: It hasn't changed much. In fact in many ways it's not as good as it used to be, because I don't agree that jazz has been elevated. First of all I was looking at, there's this tech station on TV that is 24 hours of modern technology, all of the new stuff that's coming out with computers and how it's being used in all of the different genres. And they now have a way of notating in the rap genre — they now have a way of notating, they have a music program that notates what do you call the disc? You know the record?

MR: CDs?

BW: No, no. You know like scratch.

MR: Oh they notate—

BW: Yeah. And this music program will notate it. And everybody, many people are excited about it except the rap musicians — you know they're excited about it — but the intellectuals are excited about it because now it seems to give some credence to rap. And one guy says "As though the music has to be documented," or, "now, since you can put something on paper, then it's valid."

MR: Right.

BW: Well you know, whether you like rap or not that's not the point. The point is that what validates this music is the allowance in society and by the powers that be to let the music

flourish. And in many ways that's being suppressed. You look at the festivals. Over the last ten years, everything now has to have some kind of a concept. And more and more you look at festivals year in and year out and everything is a tribute.

MR: The music of — somebody.

BW: Yeah, the music of. Now I never heard Louis Armstrong do a tribute to anybody. His great tribute was to carry the music on. When you listen to Louis Armstrong you heard those who preceded him. He didn't turn his back on the future and face the past to give validity to music. This music is only validified and further advanced in its credibility by those who look forward and constantly advance the music, you know, and build on top of what has already happened. And that idea is being totally lost. Those who want to do that are having a hard time. Those who are willing to turn their back on the future and look in the past and do a tribute to this and a tribute to that, you know, and just step back in time, they are being accepted a lot more than those who have a vision. So in many ways the Jazz at Lincoln Center has been a great deterrent to the development of this music. And then taking the young people now, look I love the fact that we have young people who want to play the music. When I started playing the music I was a young person. I was 14 years old. And you look at Kenny Dorham in his prime and Clifford Brown and all of the great heroes, they all were young. But what was happening then was a master-disciple relationship that is as essential now as it was then, maybe even more so now, because we've got to fight for it. You've got to learn from those who preceded you. And what better way than to be amongst them? You know the days when kings walked the earth, you know you wanted to come to New York because — and you wanted to stand out on 52nd and Broadway in hopes that one of your heroes would walk by, and they did. And then you went running behind. You'd find out where they were playing and you went and you crawled through the window or whatever you had to do to get in and listen to them. So in many ways the music — you know and you can't even say that it's more popular now. Okay it's being used. Jazz sells everything. And there's always those who want to be in the in. So it's hip to have some kind of knowledge or some kind of understanding of jazz now.

MR: Yes it is.

BW: Ken Burns now, whew. What a great — what a great — how can I say it?

MR: What a great service he did for us?

BW: Well — what's the word when something is like this. A service or disservice? I guess it's your way of looking at it. But it's very interesting that the top selling records of 2001 were Louis Armstrong and Duke Ellington.

MR: Yup. The reissues.

BW: You know? Now what does that say? We've got thousands — we've got many great musicians out here who need somebody to buy their records. But the top selling records in jazz in 2001 were Duke Ellington and Louis Armstrong. So now what did Ken Burns do for the music?

MR: Right. Very controversial. What's replaced that thing for young musicians where they would stand on 52nd Street and follow their heroes?

BW: There hasn't been too much. There hasn't been a replacement. In fact I teach at the New School. I've been there about six or seven years I guess. Maybe seven or eight years. And it's very interesting to see what happens semester after semester. The great thing about the New School at first, and probably still is, was the fact that young musicians from all over the world could focus on coming to New York where the music thrives, where the music is born, where the music is being developed constantly. And study at a university with these musicians who are active and constantly re-developing the music. But where do they go after school? Nowadays you bring your students together and you find out that what they're doing after school is this guy over here, he and his friend have a studio where they've got all of the latest Pro Tools and whatever, and they're actively involved in becoming producers of new hip hoppers. And then this person over here is carrying on a day job or a part time job at a bakery or something and is looking for somewhere to go out and play his instrument. And this person here has his own band and he's working at night at the Knitting Factory or these little unknown clubs. But none of them have anywhere to go where they can sit for an evening but just paying five dollars such as you used to be able to do at Birdland, the real Birdland, and sit there all evening and sip a glass of beer in the peanut gallery, and nobody bothered you. And you could listen to two bands — Miles Davis' band and as soon as he finishes, here comes Sonny Rollins' band. Or you go down to the Jazz Gallery and you listen and there is John Coltrane with his famous band with Elvin Jones and Jimmy Garrison. And when they get off the bandstand then there's Horace Silver. Those kind of things don't exist anymore. So what you try and do is make sure that all of your students have an opportunity to come hear your band, my band. Like next week I'm at the Vanguard. So all my students are going to come down to the Vanguard and they can hear the band. There was a little club for a while called Small's. I don't know if it still exists. But night after night all of the young guys and girls would crowd down there and hope to have a chance to play. There's a few places around the city, but it's not like it used to be. And now I'm not crying for it to be like it used to be. Nothing is like it used to be. That's the nature of things. Everything changes. Everything is in a constant state of flux, as it should be. But there should be some wisdom that's garnished, an accumulation of understanding how things go and how to make things better as we continue on. For something as alive as this music, it's like a

proverbial roach you can never destroy it, I don't care how many roaches you step on there's always going to be millions coming afterwards. This music will always exist. But only because of its own nature. It would be great if there was some support of the music. If there was some kind of understanding of what it is that brought this music to us in the first place. And let's be the perpetrators of those elements that allow the music to thrive and be the great cultural substance that it is. I mean you take it out of the culture — but who is advocating a day without music?

MR: Right.

BW: One day with no music anywhere. Quite different.

MR: It would be an eye opener. Well let me ask you about your process of gaining wisdom. I understand you come from a two bass family?

BW: Well a one bass family. I mean well I'm the second bass. My father was a bass player and he was my teacher.

MR: Do you have an early — what's your earliest recollection of your father playing gigs?

BW: My earliest recollection of my father playing the bass is when I was a little boy. He used to sit on the sofa and put the bass between his legs and bow. One of his favorites was Slam Stewart. And my father — and Slam Stewart always had this, he developed this great bowing style, singing, the same phrases that he would play. And my father used to emulate that. And he was a great musician. He played piano and he also played drums. And so he was always playing music around the house. There was records, his musicians would come over to the house and they'd rehearse. Once he had a duo, he and a piano player, they were working together as a duo. They'd play all these different gigs. They were called The Rollers. Kenny Andrews was his name. Kenny Andrews would come over and he and my father would practice and I'd sit there and I'd listen to them, and they used to sing, play and sing. And then when I was about 16 or 17, my father used to start taking me out on gigs with him. And he would play drums and I would play the bass. So that was my earliest recollection of — well of course when I was a kid I'd see him leaving out on gigs, I used to run behind his car sometimes. He's leaving out on the road, you know — "Daddy, Daddy, Daddy." I remember one time running behind his car and my father was heartbroken because he had to go away. So very early on.

MR: What kind of work was it? What kind of gigs was he playing, that he would take you out on? Were they club dates? Just dances? Things like that?

BW: Club dates. Dances. Parties. Everything.

MR: And were you playing jazz at that time?

BW: Um hum. Yeah. But you know jazz in those days I mean it was accessible to everybody and everybody loved it. I mean it wasn't pigeon-holed. I mean we used to play [sings] "Straighten up and fly right — Straighten up and fly right — Straighten up and fly right

—Cool down, Papa don't you blow your top." You know? And on the breaks my father used to spin his bass and catch it back in time for the next downbeat. But the music was intellectual but it didn't exclude anyone. And of course the big bands were popping and thriving and I mean you went to a dance and you had a live band. You used to play a lot of cabarets and people used to bring their own liquor and they'd have a table and they'd just order a set up. Remember cabarets?

MR: Well not like that I guess.

BW: Yeah, we used to have this big place in Philadelphia called the Seven Eleven. And it was a ballroom. And they'd have two bands, in fact one of my first gigs was with Jimmy Heath at one of these cabarets. Jimmy Heath was one band, and Sam Wied was the other band, all Philadelphia musicians. And your reservation — you'd have your own table and a big party of people come for your table. There was a big ballroom, and you bring your own liquor. And what they would serve you there at the ballroom would be ginger ale, ice, all of the things that you needed to go along with your liquor.

MR: I see. And that was called the set up.

BW: That was the set up. Potato chips and all that kind of stuff. And the cabarets happened every weekend. So I played a lot of those kind of things.

MR: Was your father in favor of you — I mean you rapidly got into the business by the time you were 16, 17 and 18 when you started going out. Did he feel okay about that? And your mother?

BW: Well he was a little more accepting of it than my mother was. My mother said, "Oh my goodness, another musician." And then when I started traveling it was like she said to me one day she says, "If I knew that this is what I had to expect when I first let you go out on your first gig I would never have done it." And I started traveling all over the world and stuff. I mean it's a hard life on those who love you you know? It's a hard life anyway but you don't look at it that way. I mean to this day I still love to travel. And my happiest time is on the bandstand. I don't want too much time between one gig and the next. But my father, now you know the first time I went out on the road was with Gene Ammons and Sonny Stitt. And the gig started on a Friday night. Nelson Boyd, remember the bass player Nelson Boyd? Dizzy Gillespie wrote the tune "Half Nelson" for him — no I mean Charlie Parker. I think Bird wrote the song "Half Nelson." He wrote that for Nelson Boyd. Nelson Boyd was a good friend of the family's. Me and my father were close buddies. Nelson was working at The Showboat in Philadelphia with Gene Ammons and Sonny Stitt. The gig got started on Tuesday. He couldn't make the gig Friday and Saturday. And so he asked my father to do it. And my father was working so my father sent me. And that was my first really big gig. I guess I was 16. I was close to 17 because I was almost ready to graduate from high school. In fact, I was 17 because I think school

had been out for about a week and I went over to The Showboat. And after the first set Gene Ammons and Sonny Stitt took me aside and started calling me Junior. They were like my two daddies. And asked me to stay with the band. So this was Friday. Saturday night after the gig I went back to Camden to pack my bag and come back over to Philadelphia to meet everybody. We were leaving out for Chicago about four in the morning. And my father and my mother helped me pack my bag. My father gave me one of his suitcases. It looked like a checkerboard, one of those checkerboard suitcases with the strap that went around the center of it you know? And my father told me all of the things to look out for on the road. How to act like I was smoking reefer and not really be smoking reefer. How to always keep my bus fare home. All of these things he told me about. Everything he told me about I ran into. And he was like that. He was prepared for me to become a musician and he prepared me to become a musician. My mother, I know her heart was pounding, you know just her little baby getting ready to go out, I had never been away from home for any length of time. So he was more prepared for it than she was. And then he passed away, this was in 1960 when I went out on the road. Then in 1965 he passed away. But by that time I had been with Gene Ammons and Sonny Stitt, I was with Sarah Vaughan, I'd been with Dakota Staton and I was with Nancy Wilson. And he had seen things start to happen for me. I had made many records by that time. And he was proud.

MR: That's great.

BW: But he was able to pass away while on the bandstand, I mean while on the gig. It was right after the gig one night, he was up in Schenectady, New York, where — by the way — his favorite bassist—

MR: Slam.

BW: Slam Stewart lived, or was born. I think it was Schenectady, New York wasn't it?

MR: Binghamton I think.

BW: Binghamton, that's where he was.

MR: Yes. Okay. That's interesting. And I see when you're doing Slam Stewart you're doing the German bow. Is that what they call it?

BW: Yes. That's what my father taught me, the German bow.

MR: That's great that he was able to see your success well underway.

BW: Yeah.

MR: Well you worked with a great list of singers. Do you learn anything different from singers than you do from playing behind horn players?

BW: I think that there's a wealth of knowledge that you learn from singers that you don't learn from horn players, or it's not as pronounced. See with singers you learn right away that you've got to play in tune. Not because they necessarily sing in tune. But in my case I

spent two years with Sarah Vaughan. Sarah Vaughan not only sang in tune all the time but she had perfect pitch. So she knew when you were out of tune. Now the antithesis to that was when I worked with Betty Carter who always sang out of tune but you still better play in tune. And out of tune did not affect her effectiveness. It was sort of like an art form for her. But with Betty Carter, she was the consummate canned heat. She was like a can of Sterno. You open it up and you put a flame to it and you get this beautiful blue flame. She could swing slower than anybody I had ever played with. She could sing a ballad or she could count off a tempo that was just perfect for the tune that you're going to play. She could lay back so far you'd be damn near half a chorus ahead of her and she's still singing in the right place.

MR: Wow. That's amazing. Are you ever tempted, I mean the first few times that happens, are you ever tempted — oh she's — should I go with her?

BW: You get scared to death man, because what happens, for the first time, you're on your own. You know? There's many revealing moments in playing this music and in your development. And in talking about Betty Carter, she would be so far behind that if you listened to her and not — so you're listening to her and you're listening to the piano player, and you know that they are in two different places. And you've got to be with the piano player. Because she knows what she's doing. And you can not skip a beat and you can't fall behind to try and — no, no, she knows exactly what she's doing. She wants you to be where you're supposed to be, so that she can be where she is. So that was a revealing moment. And in order for it to work you have to do exactly what you're supposed to do. That week that I started with Gene Ammons and Sonny Stitt, we were playing "Savoy" and we were playing it fast. And I'm watching the drummer's sock cymbal, to help me keep the time. So Sonny Stitt sees me doing this, so he goes and stands in front of the sock cymbal and looks me dead in the eye with a frown on his face. Stands in front of the sock cymbal so I can't see it, and then he moves his lips to say "Listen. Don't look, listen." A revealing moment. But you know this music makes you fearless.

MR: Fearless.

BW: Fearless. And the quicker you become fearless the easier it's going to be for you. And that's a realization — aah, I've got to be like a lion. I have to fear nothing. 'Cause what else is going to allow you, first of all, to attempt to play something different in the thirty-second chorus of this song, after you've been playing behind every soloist. You can't walk the same thing. You can't play the same notes all the time. You've got to be fearless. You've got to step out. You've got to step into places that you've never been before.

MR: That's a great statement and I wonder if the way you sound and play comes out of that. Because when I listen to you I hear a lot more stepping out than I do from some people, with your glissandos I guess I'd call it. And sometimes not constant walk but loping from one thing to the next. It's hard to describe. But you have a sound that no one else has. And I was going to ask, I might as well ask you now, do you know where your concept of a sound came from?

BW: My concept of a sound came from my father. Because my father told me early on that that was what I had to go for. And see in the days when I came up sound was everything. You listened to Coleman Hawkins and you knew Coleman Hawkins as soon as he played one note. And you knew it wasn't Ben Webster because nobody else sounded like Ben Webster and nobody sounded like Coleman Hawkins and nobody sounded like Prez and nobody sounded like Bird and nobody sounded like Miles. Miles was wise enough to early on realize that going after playing like Diz wasn't going to be his claim to fame. Everybody had their own sound. Even piano players had their own sound. Horace Silver sounded totally different from Oscar Peterson, who sounded totally different from Art Tatum, who sounded totally different from Fats Waller, who sounded totally different from Phineas Newborn. All these guys — sound was the thing. To the day nobody has ever been able to copy the sound of Art Blakey on the drums. The way Art Blakey plays the drums, the way Elvin Jones played the drums, the way Philly Jo Jones played the drums, the way Art Taylor played the drums. Everybody had their own sound. Sound was the thing. Nowadays, this is the age of mediocrity. So many people are going after the wrong thing. Drummers are trying to learn a bunch of stuff on a snare drum rather than how to get a sound on the ride cymbal. They don't realize the great value of a Ben Riley, how to ride, how to make a gig with nothing but the ride cymbal. Billy Higgins. Billy Higgins made a gig one time, the drums showed up late, so he took a chair — he had his cymbals so he took a chair and he played the chair and his cymbals. And when the drums came he was swinging so hard nobody wanted him to set up the drums. He played the whole gig with a wooden chair and a ride cymbal. Papa Jo Jones used to come to Bradley's. Remember Bradley's? Bradley's was the infamous after hours place for New York, for duos. Piano and bass. Papa Jones used to come to Bradley's with his brushes and his newspaper under his arm and he'd sit at the bar in front of the piano player and drummer and take his newspaper and fold it up, you know a folded up New York Times, and take his brushes and sit there and play brushes on the newspaper, and swing until the cows come home. I mean that was a climate, you came from the place of creativity in the days when I was learning how to play this music. So when you talk about my sound, it's not — I worked on it, that's what I went after. My father told me when I started working with all of these different singers and one night I was talking to my father, complaining

about the fact that the singers, you know you're playing the same thing over and over again. He said, "Anytime that you're able to have your instrument in your hand is a moment of reverie." And he said, "If your responsibility tonight is to do nothing but play one whole note C, play it better tonight than you played it last night, with the resolve that you'll play it better tomorrow than you play it tonight." And he used to make me — he would allow no slack in my left hand. When my hands would hurt, my fingers would be sore, and the muscles in here just feel like they're going to pop, he told me that the sound was coming from my left hand, and he was very strict about my left hand being correct at all times. Never relaxing. So when you talk about my sound, that's something that has been my predominant goal.

MR: Well it worked, for sure. I mean some of the albums that I have that you're on, with Joe Farrell and those CTI — you've got this thing happening, it's just so great. I mean congratulations I guess is all I can say, it's great. Do you have a discography of all the things you've played on over the years?

BW: You know at my web site, if you go to my recording page there's a discography there, you can click on it and it stretches out.

MR: Pretty long.

BW: And it's partial at best. I've been very fortunate to play on a lot of records and I don't know how many — I think when that discography was put together we found something like 400 albums, but that's almost ten, fifteen years old now, so I mean there's a lot.

MR: You said something that I really found interesting early on, referring to your own album you did that became "Something More" but you continued to like it. Could you pick out what would be ten albums that you would continue to like from your discography?

BW: Of mine?

MR: Well I mean of anybody you've played with.

BW: Oh okay. Harold Land "A New Shade of Blue."

MR: I have it next door, you have to sign it.

BW: It's one of my favorite albums.

MR: Me too.

BW: Mine, that's "Something More." In fact I seem to like all my CDs now that I did.

MR: I'd glad.

BW: And I've been very fortunate, I've been able to put out at least one or two a year. After that dry period between 1987 and 1996, but since 1996 I've got new product coming out all the time. "A New Shade of Blue," "Something More," those Sphere Albums.

MR: With Charlie Rouse.

BW: With Charlie Rouse and Kenny Barron and Ben Riley. Oh I don't know.

MR: How about something with Herbie? Anything in particular?

BW: Yeah the "Mwandishi." I think we did about five or six, something like that.

MR: There was some nice writing on those things.

BW: Mmm. Oh yeah. "The Prisoner." Oh Herbie did some of his best writing on that.

MR: Well let me play something for you and see if you can recall.

[audio interlude]

BW: It's me and Kenny Baron. "Someday My Prince Will Come."

MR: Right. It's got a very interesting ending on it. Do you recall? I think you played that note almost the whole piece.

BW: Yeah.

MR: And I believe this is a live thing too, isn't it? Like we're not done yet.

BW: Art Blakey used to do that. [sings] Better buy a Bird's Eye.

MR: Oh. Better buy a Bird's Eye.

BW: Yeah. For frozen string beans.

MR: I'll be darned.

BW: Frozen green peas. Better buy a Bird's Eye. Yeah. He and Lee Morgan. Lee Morgan and he used to do that. That was "Two in One?"

MR: "Two Is One."

BW: "Two Is One," yeah. We did that in Perusia. It was a live date. It was during the Umbria Jazz Festival one year in Perusia, And that's what goes on for live five or six days. And they tried to emulate some of the popular jazz clubs in New York, like Bradley's, which we were at, an emulation of Bradley's. They had one club that was like The Vanguard, they had another one that was like Birdland. But that's when we did that. Yeah that was a live date.

MR: Nice moment. Here's a thing — I just thought of your sound on this thing, if I can make it go.

[audio interlude]

BW: Houston Person?

MR: Yeah. I love those things you do. A date like this, would there be any rehearsal?

BW: I mean you know some of the best records have been made in six hours. And if you had a rehearsal the day before that was a luxury. Most of the time there wasn't. You know who Rudy VanGelder is?

MR: Um hum.

BW: And you set up and you start playing. You do two, three takes. But I mean the first take, if the first take is not the take well then that was a perfect rehearsal. You know?

MR: That's a good way to put it.

BW: So you know you've got to — and that's another thing that kids are not understanding these days — you've got to make every moment count. When you go to these record

dates, now it's different when you're going in and all of these are your friends and you all came together because I love the way you play and you love the way I play. But then what about when you get called for one of these dates and it's a record date, which I mean there was a time when this happened every day all day long, you got about three or four dates a day, and you're going from one to the other and you never played any of this music. And you're there with people of varying degrees of ability in reading music. But you'd better bet that all of these people can read music, right? So you've got to read music too. But maybe you're not as fast as this guy over here, you know? But when you get into the studio and you set up, there's all kinds of technical problems that are going happen and you've got to know how to use every moment to get your stuff together. And there's a passage in the music that you're not too clear about. You've got to know how to listen to what's going on to answer your questions. Because ain't nobody — nobody has any time to teach you. Like my father told me, one time we were on the bandstand and in between tunes I'm sort of like practicing and my father took his sticks — he's playing the drums — and hitting my strings, and he says, "No practicing on the bandstand." He says, "Either you're ready or you're not." So when you walk in there you've got to be ready and you've got to know how to use opportunities that are occurring all the time to help you to be ready so that when it comes time and it goes okay, everybody's ready, all the technical problems are solved, now you don't want to be the one that ruins the take. Right? So now you've taken all this time when everybody else had to stop, they had to stop for all these other things, you're getting your stuff together. So now you play the music, and wow, you're going to get called back again because you played the hell out of it. Because you knew how to use — and the problems that you had here this time you won't have next time.

MR: Especially important, you've done your share of commercials and movie scores — time is money, right?

BW: Time is money. When I first moved out to California and then Ray Brown left Oscar Peterson and he came to California, then Ray Brown and I became very close and I became his number one sub. And he would send me on anything and everything. One time I had to go out to Universal Studios to do "McKenna's Gold" with Gregory Peck. And I was the principal bassist. We had eight basses. All right? So Ray couldn't make it and he was the principal bassist, so now I'm the principal bassist. I said "Ray, what do you want me to do?" He said "go on now and take charge." You know? Any doubt that I had he never had. So I'm the one determining when it's down bow, when it's up bow. But you learn how to adapt real quick. And on these dates here, if it's not done today it won't be done. You don't have two or three days, much less two or three months, to do

this record. We're going to make this record by dinnertime. We're going to start at eleven o'clock in the morning and we're going to be finished by six.

MR: It seems high pressure.

BW: Yeah but you know it's very interesting. In those days also, on the bandstand a gig consisted of five sets a night. In many situations it was 40 on, 20 off. You played five sets. And it was nothing to finish three o'clock in the morning. Nowadays we're spoiled. We don't want to play more than two sets. If you've got to play a third set on Saturday night, oh my goodness. You know you got used to being finished work by one o'clock, getting home on time to see "Cheers" on TV.

MR: Now if I was to come to the Village Vanguard when your group is playing there, will I hear two sets?

BW: Two sets.

MR: But they're fairly long sets.

BW: Yeah. You know about 70 minutes.

MR: And do they turn the audience over for those things?

BW: Hopefully.

MR: Yup.

BW: If there's some people waiting. If there's enough people waiting outside. You know the thing that you hear too often is after you finish playing the set and the guy off the stage is making his announcement, saying, "You're all invited to the second set for just a ten dollar minimum." That means that there's not enough people to put you all out and fill up the room again. It's nice when after you finish your first set, thank everyone for coming and please come back again. Oh that's so nice because you've got a new set of people to come in. You're going to turn over the house.

MR: With the small number of clubs of stature like the Vanguard and the Blue Note, is it hard to get your own group in there? What do you have to do to get on the schedule?

BW: Well man, these people are receiving tapes and press kits and requests every day. It's a buyer's market now. There's more bands than there are places to work. And then what is fading out but what was the predominant determining factor over the last ten years was these record companies getting their new artists into these clubs and their new artists, the club being able to pay for it because the new artist, they're not charging that much, plus the record company is buying 500 seats for the week. So then the club owner, he or she has to do nothing. I'm going to have this person here in my club who's getting fresh ink, this is the person that's being written about, this is the person that's being nominated for the Grammy, this is the person that this record company is pushing. Right? And the record company has bought 500 seats for the week, which means they're going to fill them up with record execs. But the club owners got warm bodies in the seats and that's

the bottom line for them. That's all they care about. But then that's not happening. So then established artists who have the track record and all of the credentials may not get the gig. Because this is not the person who they put on the cover of *Jazz Times* this month. Oh yeah, we know of him, oh yeah he's great. But then this new little shiny guy, that everybody's talking about right now. And there's this one club for all of these different variables. So you can see the situation.

MR: Let me just ask you briefly about your compositions. Do you write at the piano? Do you start from your bass? How does a tune start for you?

BW: It may come from anywhere. It may start on the piano, it may start on the bass, it may start in a dream. But someone said something very interesting and that was as far as composing, try not to compose from the piano because you stand a chance of being limited by your ability to play the piano. But nevertheless, an idea can come from wherever. One of my most-liked tunes it seems is "Christina." And "Christina" came from a request from my sister to write a song for her newborn daughter. So the song was inspired by this little girl's vibe, persona, whatever. And it turns out that it's one that works real well. But yeah, it can come from — but at some point I've got to sit down at the piano and figure it out. It's not important for me to be able to play it. It's important for me to be able to write it. And then I can get the piano player to play it.

MR: Yeah right. It'll do slightly better. Is there anybody that you're aware of writing — hopefully it's you maybe — what will become the standards.

BW: I hope it's me.

MR: Wouldn't that be great?

BW: Yeah. You know a friend of mine, we were just talking about that the other day. One of the things that Herbie Hancock and Wayne Shorter and Ron Carter, since when you're talking about Herbie and Wayne and Ron, you know you don't have to use their last names, everybody knows who you're talking about. One of the things that perpetrated their music was the fact that they played each other's music. And that's sort of the kind of thing that Bird and Monk and Miles and Dizzy, they did also. They played each other's music, which is what we need to do more of. We need to play more of our contemporaries' music. And that helps make the music standards. A lot of the standards that we call standards now came from plays, or came from movies, but a standard is never a standard if it's only played once. It's got to be played over and over again in different kind of situations. And that's what makes it a standard. And I mean I'd like to see more of our music, meaning the jazz compositions, becoming standard material. I guess what helps is the kind of genres that it's played in, the kind of situations that the music is used for.

MR: I think it helps too if there's a lyric.

BW: It always helps if there's a lyric.

MR: Yeah. People can put the lyric in your head as you're hearing it.

BW: People like to sing these songs that they like. I'm doing a project for this summer, I'm going out with a singer named Melissa Walker. You know Melissa Walker?

MR: No.

BW: She's a very good singer. And she wants me to write music that fits her in. And a couple of years back I did a project for a Japanese singer and I wrote these songs and I wrote lyrics. And that was the first time I wrote lyrics. And they came out really good. So it's another challenge that I have in front of me, to write these songs with lyrics. And as you said it stands a better chance of something becoming more standard material.

MR: Well this has been fascinating for me.

BW: Me too.

MR: Is there anything that I should have asked you that I didn't?

BW: Uh um. No. I enjoyed this interview because you didn't ask me standard kind of things, you asked me things that gave me a chance to just talk.

MR: Good.

BW: And you can always go to the Internet and find out anything you want.

MR: More than you ever need to know.

BW: That's right. No this was fun.

MR: Well I wish you the best with your quartet and I hope to catch you sometime.

BW: Are you going to be in town next week?

MR: I'm not scheduled.

BW: When are you going back?

MR: We're going back Tuesday.

BW: Well you're only going to Clinton, New Jersey, right?

MR: Clinton, New York.

BW: Clinton, New York. Not even New Jersey.

MR: It's only five hours.

BW: Oh you drove?

MR: Yeah.

BW: It's a drive, huh? So what's up there? You are up near Albany?

MR: We are past Albany in Utica. We're outside Utica.

BW: So you're going back when?

MR: Tuesday morning.

BW: Well I open Tuesday night. That's the day after tomorrow.

MR: I could extend our stay.

BW: Well if you can, you're invited.

MR: All right.

BW: At the Vanguard.

MR: Great. Well thank you for your time.

BW: Thank you.